

Memetic language as a vector of political polarisation

A corpus-linguistic approach

(TW: mentions of racism, sexism, and hate-speech)

Prefatory Matters

- Memes, both pictorial and textual, are often used to amplify political ideologies.
- Often times, memes trivialise what would otherwise be perturbing by yoking them to concepts that people find ‘based’.
- Once a meme garners enough virality, elements of those memes may be added to the platform’s lexicon.
- On platform’s with strong content moderation, memetic elements that are seemingly innocuous, may be used to by pass filters and disseminate potentially harmful messages.
- The memetic jargon used can be a telltale sign of a person’s political leaning.
- For this corpus analysis, the following platforms will serve as datasets : 4chan, Reddit, and Instagram.

Washington Shenanigans

- Following the barrage of self-initiated airstrikes on the Republic of Iran, the whitehouse had the following video posted on the platform X
 - <https://x.com/WhiteHouse/status/2029741548791853331>
- I have added this video here to illustrate how memetic elements can be used to justify actions without actual reasons.
- The 40 second video features popular hollywood scenes which espouse vengeance, along with the background music from the game Mortal Kombat, which is a highly violent game. The final punchline in the video is also from the aforementioned game.
- The hollywood scenes imply that the airstrikes are a form of vengeance and not imperialist violence.
- The Mortal Kombat theme makes the violence palatable and quite fun to view, with the final punchline portraying America as P1. (P.S This would be like putting DOOM music on a school shooting POV video to trivialise the real world consequences of the event.)

6-7 would have been better



- The words 'foid', 'jestermaxxing', and 'stacy' are jargons used in subreddits that lean towards incel culture.
- 'Foid' is used to dehumanise women by denying them full human status. The term implies women are biologically driven automatons without genuine interiority or agency. Heavy usage on incel forums, Telegram incel channels, and archived 4chan threads.
- 'Stacy' on the other hand refers to women who only date men who are conventionally attractive.
- 4chan, and subreddits that promote incel culture consider themselves 'red-pilled' and 'based' when using such jargons.

NEUTRALISED WORD BANK

Conservative / Manosphere

redpill · trad masculinity · right-wing indian

HIERARCHY: alpha beta sigma chad

stacy becky normie

PEJORATIVES: cuck soyboy foid

western spy groomer porki meat eater

libtard sickular

EPISTEMIC: redpilled blackpilled

bluepilled based

SMV/LOOKS: looksmaxxing jetermaxxing

hypergamy SMV cope rope

ANTI-WOKE: woke mind virus tradwife

lets go brandon dark brandon

Nationalist

majoritarian · anti-secular · anti-commie

ANTI-MUSLIM: jihad tukde tukde gang

love jihad land jihad green jihad mullah

jehadis

NATIONALIST IDENTITY: anti-national

urban naxal khalistani

ANTI-SECULAR / LEFT: commie pseudo-secular

librandu sickular Mughal apologist

beef lobby conversion mafia cattle smuggler

Naxal sympathizer

Fascist / Neo-Nazi

accelerationist · white genocide

NUMERIC CODES: 1488 14/88

RACE REALISM: race realism great replacement

white genocide ZOG ((echoes))

4CHAN MEMETIC: kek pepe wew lad moon man

hwndu based and redpilled

CAMOUFLAGED: seig heil gay

Anarchist

anti-state · mutual aid

ACAB / ANTI-POLICE: acab 1312 acabworld

bootlicker pig

DIRECT ACTION: direct action mutual aid

prefiguration the commune bread book

kropotkin

ANTI-PROPERTY: property is theft rent is theft

smash the state black bloc antifa

LIBERATION: abolish prisons

lgbtq+ liberation no gods no masters

Communist / Far-left

ML · tankie · accelerationism

MARXIST CORE: comrade seizing the means

surplus value bourgeois class traitor

praxis

INTRA-LEFT LABELS: tankie demsoc ML

shitlib anarcho-tyranny

FUTURIST: accelerationism

fully automated luxury gay space communism

Eco-extremist / Deep Green

degrowth · antinatalism

COLLAPSE: overshoot degrowth

collapse now climate suicide

great simplification

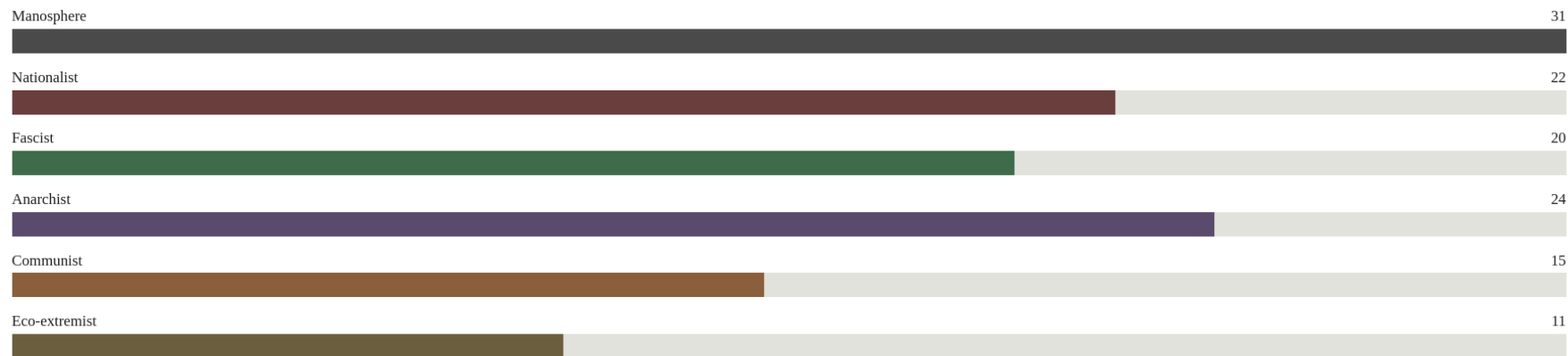
ANTINATALIST: antinatalism birth strike

VHEM rewilding

SELF-LABEL: ecofascism

Metrics – Lexical Richness

Lexical richness: total distinct terms

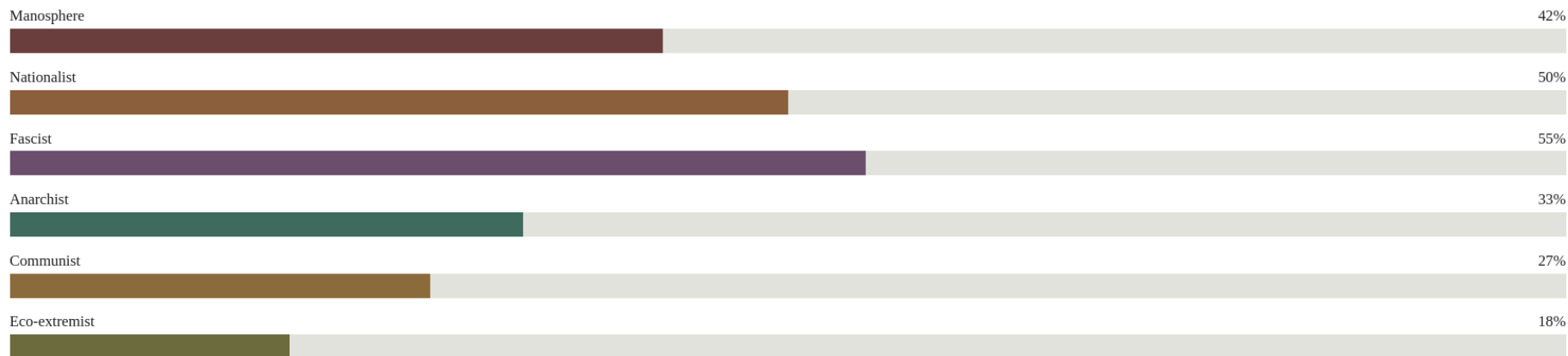


Manosphere remains lexically richest (31 terms). Nationalist wordbank contains 22 distinct terms after including all provided items (anti-muslim, identity, anti-secular). Eco-extremist narrowest.

Fringe ideologies with stronger identity construction (hierarchy, gender, race) develop larger specialised vocabularies.

Metrics – Out-group Pejorative Density

Out-group pejorative density (% of total terms)



Fascist highest (55%), followed closely by Nationalist (50%). Nationalist's high pejorative density driven by terms like jihad, love jihad, commie, beef lobby, conversion mafia, etc.

The higher the density, the more the ideology relies on enemy construction to unify members.

Metrics – Dog whistle density

Coded language & dogwhistle density (%)



The more cryptic the language, the less moderated it is, and the more it gets proliferated. Words like 'kek' are often not moderated.

Metrics and Insights

- The corpus analysis of these memetic terms purvey some insight into their virality, efficiency and polarisation capabilities.
- Lexical richness is a telltale sign of how established and how fringe an ideology is. The more extreme and the more established it is, the more it shows signs of dedicated lexica. The manosphere/incel culture, given its large amount of subscribers, exhibits larger lexical richness.
- Out-group Pejorative Density indicates how fringe an ideology is. The more enemies they have, the more they tend to be outliers. This is not a metric that concerns numbers, but a metric that is pseudo-quantitative. Technically it attempts to, almost faithfully, quantify how prevalent victimhood is in the concerned ideology.
- Dog whistle density can be used to see how deeply entrenched words of a specific political ideology are in social-media platforms.

Note: This analysis I have undertaken does not take into consideration emojis. Of all forms of cryptic messages, emojis have become prevalent currently, with the coffee cup used to represent women disparagingly and the 'ninja' emoji used as a dog-whistle for the racial slur concerned with people of African descent.

Sources & Methodology

- The raw source, given its explicit nature, cannot be displayed here.
- However, I took a small sample of memes in a random fashion from the following sites/subreddits
 - <https://4chan.org/pol>
 - <https://4chan.org/r9k>
 - <https://reddit.com/IndiaSpeaks>
 - <https://reddit.com/TheRedPill>
 - <https://reddit.com/DankIndianMemes>
 - <https://instagram.com>
- Another thing to note is, of all the affixes in memetic language, the most productive one by far is -maxxing.
- Comparision was done once a sample size of 50 was acquired.